

Policy Debate Worksheet: Should Phones Be Banned in CT Schools?

Pathways: Economics & Finance Workshop

Lecture 1: Economic Decision-Making and Everyday Choices

Your Stakeholder Group: _____

Group Members: _____

House Bill 5035

A **bell-to-bell** phone ban in all Connecticut public schools. Students may bring phones but must store them during the school day (in a backpack, locker, or Yondr pouch—each district chooses).

Key Facts

- New Haven pilot: **\$375,000** for Yondr pouches across 10 schools (5,800 students).
- That's roughly **\$65 per student** if pouches are used.
- Funded by **school districts**—no dedicated state funding in the bill.
- The bill passed the CT House with strong bipartisan support (**117–31**).
- Average U.S. teen spends **4.8 hours/day** on their phone (Common Sense Media, 2023).

Today's Concepts

Concept	Definition
Opportunity Cost	The value of the next best alternative when you make a decision. Includes both direct costs (money spent) and foregone benefits.
Sunk Cost	A cost you cannot recover —money, time, or effort already spent and gone forever.
Sunk Cost Fallacy	Letting past, unrecoverable costs influence your future decisions—staying on a path just because you've already invested in it.

Questions

1. What are the **benefits** of the phone ban for your stakeholder group?

2. What are the **opportunity costs** of the phone ban for your stakeholder group?

3. Are there any sunk costs your group should be aware of? Should they affect the decision?

4. What is your group's policy recommendation? Circle one and explain why.

- a) Full ban (Yondr pouches for all students)
- b) Partial ban (phones stored in backpacks/lockers, no pouches)
- c) No ban (keep current rules)
- d) Other (describe your own policy below)

Explain your reasoning: